

Charles & Helen Bacon

ROOTED IN FAMILY



Family History StoryBooks

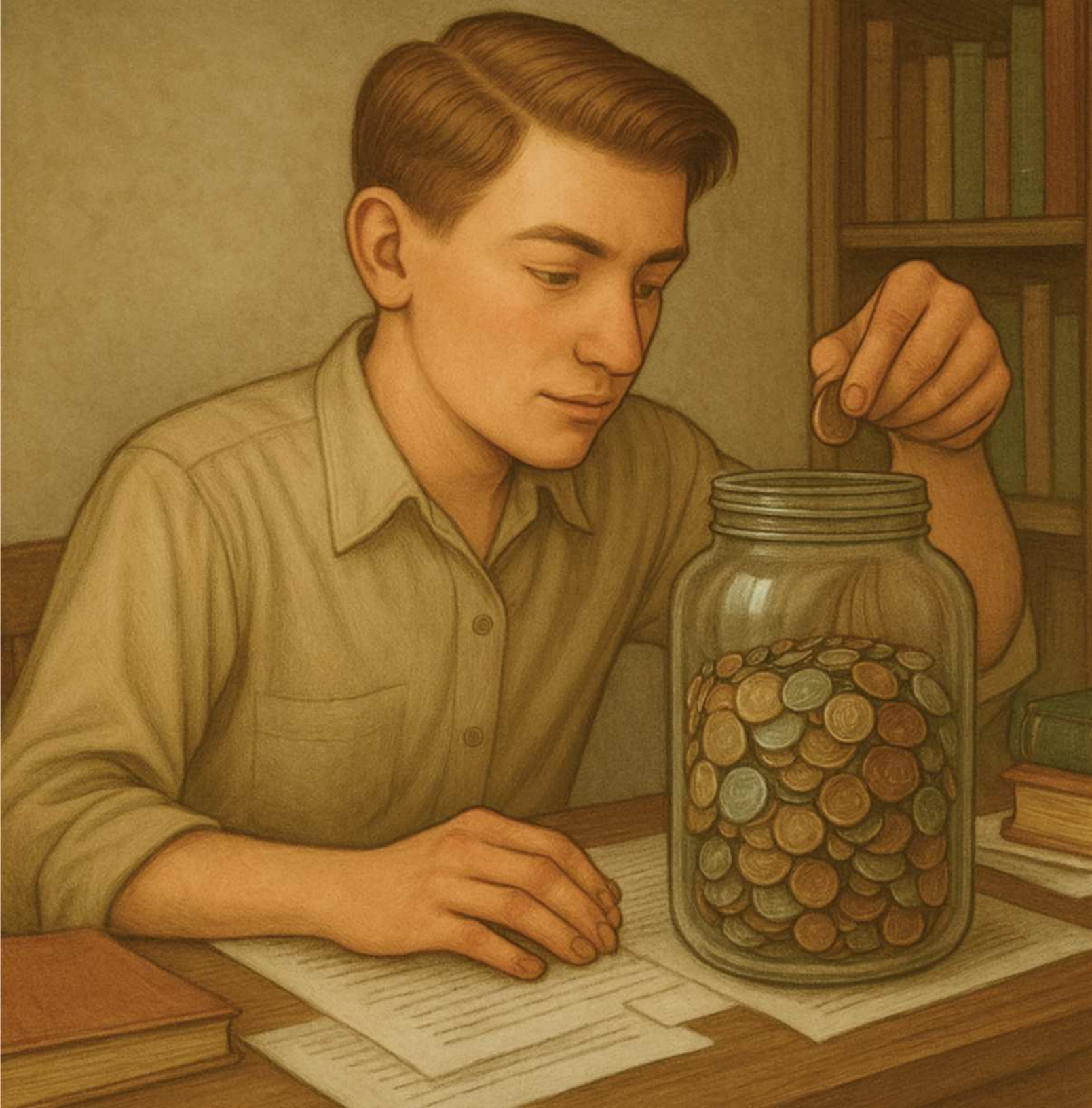
Long ago, in a small town called St. Croix Falls, Wisconsin, a boy named Charles was born on a chilly winter day in 1922. He had three brothers and spent much of his childhood outside with them. When Charles was just six years old, his younger brother, Howard, became very sick and passed away. Not long after, Charles's father also died from the same illness.

Even through the heartbreak, Charles was brave and hardworking. He helped run a little family dairy farm, called Bacon's Dairy, with his brothers and their mother. He also learned how to fish and hunt so he could help feed the family. Sometimes Charles used trout tickling to catch trout with his bare hands. In the cold Wisconsin winters, he would ski through the snow on homemade skis.

One time, he fell through the ice on the reservoir! Thinking fast, he clawed his way back onto the ice and headed home. His pants froze stiff as boards on the way. A kind neighbor invited him into their home and helped him dry off before he made it the rest of the way to his home..

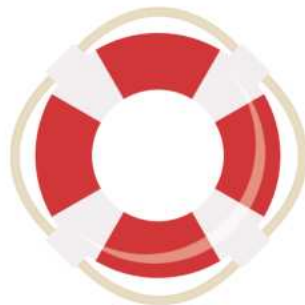






Even with all the hard times, Charles found joy in the outdoors. He went scuba diving with the town doctor's old oxygen tanks and spent hours swimming in the river. He became a lifeguard and watched over swimmers on the wide, beautiful St. Croix River.

Charles loved school and worked hard. He graduated in 1939 and was given a special chance to attend college in North Dakota, thanks to his kind aunt and uncle. At first, he lived with them, but the next year he wanted to live on campus. So, he worked for a whole year to earn enough money. College was expensive, but Charles had a plan. After two years of studying, he joined the military—not just to serve, but to save enough money to finish school later.



Far away in Missouri, in 1927, a little girl named Helen was born. She was the youngest of four children. Her dad was a dentist, and her mom stayed home to take care of the family. When Helen was five, her parents separated. She moved back and forth between her mom's home in Idaho and her dad's home in Montana, one year here, one year there.

Helen didn't talk much about her childhood. It wasn't always happy. One time, she needed new shoes, but her father sent some that were too small. She wore them anyway, even though her feet hurt every day. Her dad remarried, and Helen often felt left out while her new siblings got better clothes and more attention. But Helen didn't let the hard times stop her from working hard and moving forward.

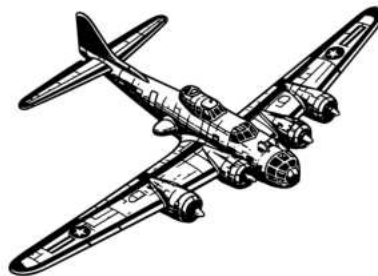






As Helen got older, she worked at many jobs. She even made so much money that her dad once complained she earned too much for him to claim her on his taxes! During World War II, when she was just 16 years old, Helen joined thousands of other women to work on airplanes at the Spokane Army Air Depot. She was smart, careful, and proud to help her country.

Helen fixed airplane engines and took special classes to learn even more. She was a real-life Rosie the Riveter—strong, skilled, and determined. The war was changing the world, and Helen was doing her part to keep the airplanes flying high.



In 1942, Charles joined the Marines. He wanted to be a pilot, so he needed two years of college first. He trained all across the country—in Iowa, Kansas, Texas, and California—learning to fly powerful SBD Dauntless dive bombers. By January of 1944, he was ready for his biggest journey yet: flying over the South Pacific during the war.

Charles flew on dangerous missions, dropping bombs and helping his crew. One day, his plane had a problem and went down in the ocean! Charles and his gunner escaped just in time before the plane sank beneath the waves.

Even while at war, Charles made the most of his experience. He looked for coconuts, swam in the sea, and collected seashells. His love for nature never left him.







One day, at a military base in California called El Toro, Charles met a quiet, friendly man named Charles Lindbergh—the famous pilot who flew across the Atlantic Ocean. They chatted about planes, engines, and adventures.

Later on, their paths crossed on an island in the South Pacific. Charles had an excellent radio that could pick up news from almost anywhere in the world. Whenever he tuned in to hear what was happening back at home, Lindbergh would come sit at the steps of Charles's hut to listen with him. Lindbergh loved to swim, and the two became swim buddies, diving into coral pools and talking about sea life. Lindbergh once swam through a narrow underwater tunnel and scraped his side on the coral. As they became friends, Charles Bacon learned that even someone famous could be kind and ordinary, just like anyone else.



Charles's squadron moved from island to island during the war. In late 1944, his group flew to a little island called Emirau. Each day, they wound up the propellers on their planes by hand and took short flights to keep them ready. But most of the time, they had free hours to explore. Charles went swimming, hiked across the island, planted palm trees by his tent, and even collected a giant clam shell!

Soon, the squadron flew to the Philippines. One mission was especially tricky: Charles's plane was making strange noises, so he turned back—but then it started working again. When he rejoined the mission, the other planes had already damaged a big bridge. He spotted enemy trucks trying to escape into a canyon. Charles destroyed the second bridge to block their path, then bombed the lead and last trucks before he and the other pilots stopped the rest. It was a dangerous mission, but Charles stayed calm and focused. Charles's many successful missions and heroisms earned him six Air Medals and the Distinguished Flying Cross.







When the war began to wrap up, Charles and five of his fellow pilots started the long trip back to the United States. They flew from island to island—Zamboanga to Samar, then to Palau. They hitched a ride to Guam on a big empty transport plane, and Charles even flew part of the way himself!

From Guam, they waited for a flight to Hawaii. When it was finally their turn, they hopped on a plane that took them to Kwajalein. There, they heard big news: the war in Europe was over! They cheered, refueled, and kept flying—first to Johnston Island, then to Hawaii. In Honolulu, they were given a car and driver and treated to island tours, sandwiches, and milkshakes. After a few relaxing days, they boarded the Pan American Clipper plane and flew 14 hours to California. At last, on May 12, 1945, they saw the Golden Gate Bridge. Charles was finally home.



After the war, Charles remained with the Marines for a short time instructing new pilots in North Carolina. He was released from active duty at the end of 1945, but stayed on inactive duty until 1959 and was almost called back during the Korean War. During those years, Charles focused on something new—finishing college. He switched his major to forestry and moved to Missoula, Montana, to attend the University of Montana.

That's where he met Helen. She was studying sociology and working hard toward graduation. They met in a first aid class, and soon, their friendship turned into love. During the summer of 1950, Charles worked in a forest lookout tower watching for fires. They got married after school started again on September 10th in Livingston, Montana.







Charles and Helen took a honeymoon trip to California. It was exciting, but also a little bit scary—their car was broken into, and Charles's wedding suit and camera were stolen! Still, they stayed cheerful and made the best of it.

After Charles graduated from college in 1951, the couple moved to Longview, Washington. It was time to start their new life together. Charles began working at a paper mill, using his forestry knowledge to help make paper. Helen worked at the Longview Public Library. This was a job she enjoyed while the couple began dreaming of having a family.



Charles and Helen welcomed their first baby, Barbara Ann, in 1955. One year later, they had Linda Lee. Then in 1959, William Arthur was born—they called him Bill. Their hearts were full. Life was sometimes busy and loud, but full of laughter and love.

Charles loved the outdoors and taught his kids how to fish, hike, and camp. He planted trees, berry bushes, and even strawberry plants in their big backyard. They often went clamming on the Long Beach Peninsula. The three kids would stomp in circles on the wet sand beach to find clam holes, and Charles would dig the sand away. When he'd gotten most of the sand out, the kids would dig the clam out with their hands—sometimes they went all the way to their shoulders!

It was hard work, but when they finished, they went to another beach where they searched for sand dollars, shells and glass balls. It was very exciting as over the years each of the children found a glass ball. Going to the beach was immensely fun and created many happy memories.







In 1958, Helen's sister, Dorothy, joined The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. Helen wasn't happy about it. She even invited missionaries over so she could prove the church wrong. When they came, she smoked the entire time to see how they'd react. But then, something unexpected happened.

Later that night, Helen went into her room with the Book of Mormon and started to read. Almost right away, she felt something warm and peaceful in her heart. She knew it was true. On August 20, 1960, Helen was baptized. Her testimony only grew stronger. She became the best Visiting Teacher in her ward and began learning about family history, a love that would last her whole life.



Every evening, the comforting smell of something warm and homemade drifted from Helen's kitchen. She cooked dinner every single night, without fail. On days when the family returned from clamming trips to the coast, sandy and tired, Helen would roll up her sleeves and turn the fresh razor clams into golden, crispy perfection. Her fried clams became a family favorite.

Helen loved the thrill of car racing, often taking the children to stock car races in town and keeping up with NASCAR on the television, always rooting for her favorite drivers. But her real joy came in serving others. Whether it was bringing dinner to a family in need or visiting those who hadn't come to church in a while, she did it faithfully—often alone, but without hesitation.







Charles didn't join the church right away. But he supported Helen and welcomed the missionaries to dinner. In 1975, they challenged him: "Go to church every time you catch a fish on Sunday." Well, Charles was a great fisherman, and that year, he caught a lot of fish! He started going to church more and more—and something began to change inside him.

Later that year, Bill gave a talk at stake conference and said, "My number one goal is to baptize my father." He'd promised the Lord he would pray for his dad every day. Unbeknownst to him, Charles was sitting in the congregation! During a hunting trip sometime after, someone offered Charles a cup of coffee. He said, "No thanks, I'll have hot chocolate." He looked right at Bill and smiled. On December 25, 1975—Charles was baptized by 16-year-old Bill. So many people came that they couldn't fit in the room! It was a Christmas no one would ever forget.



On April 27, 1978, Charles, Helen, and their children went to the Salt Lake Temple. There, they were sealed together forever. It was a joyful, sacred day—something they had hoped and prayed for.

Charles and Helen stayed strong in the gospel and served faithfully in many church callings. When the Seattle Temple was dedicated in 1980, they were thrilled. Later, when the Portland Temple opened, they attended there too. Helen continued her work in family history and even traveled to Salt Lake City to visit the giant genealogy library. Together, Charles and Helen helped build a legacy of faith.







In the summer of 2000, Charles and Helen celebrated 50 years of marriage! Family came from near and far. The grandkids were out of school, so everyone could be there—except for one grandson who was serving a mission in Chile. They had a fancy dinner on Friday and a barbecue in the park on Saturday with lots of food, laughter, and love.

It was a perfect celebration. Shortly after, Charles was not feeling well and was diagnosed with an aggressive cancer. The children gathered to spend time with their dad and receive father's blessings. Charles passed away on November 3, 2000. Almost 6 years later, when the family realized that Helen was sick, they again gathered together. They shared memories, challenged for favorite child position, confessed ownership of family mishaps and laughed as they relived fond memories of growing up together in the Bacon home on Beacon Hill. She passed away peacefully on August 3, 2006. But their story doesn't end there—it lives on in their children, grandchildren, great grandchildren and the faith they planted.



Charles and Helen's life together wasn't always easy, but it was always full of love. They worked hard, served faithfully, and built a family that stayed close through the years. They taught their children to work, to pray, and to trust in the Lord.

Whether it was digging for clams, discussing gospel principles, or weeding the vegetable garden, every moment helped shape a family that knew where it came from—and where it was going. Because Charles and Helen were sealed in the temple, their family is forever. And that, more than anything, is the greatest adventure of all.





Charles Arthur Bacon

JANUARY 28, 1922 - NOVEMBER 3, 2000

Helen Virginia Crissey

OCTOBER 16, 1927 - AUGUST 3, 2006

ROOTED IN FAMILY

My Relationship:



FamilySearch.org ID

Charles Arther Bacon: KW8H-H5H

Helen Virginia Crissey: KW8H-H54

Book Created for Charles and Helen's children,
grandchildren, and great-grandchildren

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Story and illustrations by Madeline Harmer

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Charles at abt age 23



Helen Virginia Crissey



Helen and Charles on their Honeymoon



Charles standing in front of his plane



NOSE-EYE VIEW—At work inside the KO Kid, B-24, are (front to rear): W. Balbach, Lois Laseter and Helen Crissey. Picture taken through hole left by removal of chin's nose.

16 year old Helen (center) working in the engine cavity of an airplane



**L to R: Barbara, Helen, William,
and Linda in 1959**



**William and Charles in the
baptismal font, Christmas Day 1975**



Charles and Helen



**L to R: Barbara, William, and Linda
in 1981**